Paul's Gospel Is Independent of the Judean Churches

Paul's gospel and apostleship were never subordinate to Jerusalem — confirmed by the Judean churches' own testimony and the Jerusalem apostles' own recognition.

Where this study fits

Galatians · sixteen studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–5 The Ground of Liberty	**02** 1:6–10 The One True Gospel	**03** 1:11–17 Paul's Independent Revelation	**04** 1:18–2:10 **Paul's Gospel Is Independent of the Judean Churches**
05 2:11–21 Peter Goes Back to School	**06** 3:1–5 Under a Spell	**07** 3:6–14 Blessing or a Curse	**08** 3:15–29 The Superiority of the Promise to the Law
09 4:1–11 When I Became a Man	**10** 4:12–20 A Steel Fist in a Velvet Glove	**11** 4:21–31 Paul's Old Testament Story	**12** 5:1–12 Taking a Stand in Liberty
13 5:13–26 Walk in the Spirit	**14** 6:1–5 Brothers and Burdens	**15** 6:6–10 Sowing and Reaping	**16** 6:11–18 Teaching the Truth

Paul's five visits to Jerusalem

Introduction · Acts and Galatians together

#	Visit	Acts	Galatians	What happened
1	**After leaving Damascus**	9:26–30	**1:18–20**	Barnabas brings him to the apostles; he preaches boldly
2	**The famine visit**	11:27–30	**2:1–10**	Relief from Antioch; Paul discusses his gospel privately
3	The Jerusalem Council	15	—	The law-and-grace question settled (A.D. 49/50)
4	End of the second journey	—	—	Greets the church, returns to Antioch
5	The final visit	—	—	Taken in the temple; two years in Caesarea, two in Rome

Galatians covers visits 1 and 2 only — it was written before visit 3, the council.

Why 2:1–10 is the famine visit, not the council

Galatians 1:20; 2:10 · The commentary's three reasons

1

A solemn oath
“Before God, I do not lie” (1:20). Paul is listing every visit; skipping one would be a lie.

ψεύδομαι
to speak falsely · Pres. Ind. 1st Sg.

2

No council letter cited
Acts 15 ended with a letter to the Gentile churches. Paul would surely have quoted it to settle the matter.

3

Only “remember the poor”
2:10 says nothing about things strangled or blood — requests in the council's letter.

πτωχῶν
the destitute · Gen. Pl.

Conclusion: Galatians 2:1–10 is the famine visit of Acts 11:27–30 — A.D. 48, before the council of A.D. 49/50.

Paul's early travels

Galatians 1:18–21 · Outline I.A–B

After three years	Barnabas vouches	Disputes with Hellenists	Sent away	Syria and Cilicia
Up to Jerusalem to see Peter; only James besides	The disciples were afraid; Barnabas brings him to the apostles	As Stephen had — and they seek to kill him	Down to Caesarea and off to Tarsus	Ministry in his home region
1:18–19	*Acts 9:26–28*	*Acts 9:29*	*Acts 9:30*	*1:21*

“to see Peter” — v.18
ἱστορῆσαι Aor. Act. Inf.

- To visit and become acquainted — not to be taught

“before God, I do not lie” — v.20
ψεύδομαι Pres. Ind. 1st Sg.

- A solemn oath: this account of his visits is complete

How the Judean churches responded

Galatians 1:22–24 · Outline I.C

They did not know him · v.22
ἀγνοούμενος Pres. Pass. Ptc.

"unknown by face to the churches of Judea" — a stranger by sight

They heard · v.23

"He who formerly persecuted us now preaches the faith which he once tried to destroy"

They glorified God · v.24
ἐδόξαζον Imperf. Act.

"they glorified God in me" — grace, not Paul's achievement

Acts 9:31 — walking in the fear of the Lord and the comfort of the Holy Spirit, the church multiplied.

The famine visit: who went, and why

Galatians 2:1–2 · Outline II.A–B

The representatives — vv.1–2a

Time 14 years after Paul's conversion

Team Paul (leader), Barnabas, and Titus — a Gentile, uncircumcised; his first mention

Text The gospel Paul preached — the gospel of grace

The reason — v.2

By revelation Agabus foretold the famine (Acts 11:27–30); not summoned

Privately not a council or public meeting

And communicated **ἀνεθέμην** — laid it before them to be on the same page, not to ask if it was true

“Lest I might run, or had run, in vain” — if Jerusalem demanded law-keeping of Gentiles, Paul would be running uphill.

The disruption: liberty under attack

Galatians 2:3–5 · Outline II.C.1–2

Slipped in	**ψευδαδέλφους** false brothers — by stealth, under false pretenses (v.4a)
Spied out	**κατασκοπῆσαι** “our liberty which we have in Christ Jesus” (v.4b)
To enslave	**καταδουλώσουσιν** bring us back into the bondage of the law (v.4c)
Targeted Titus	a Greek, uncircumcised — compel him and set a precedent (v.3)

Paul's response — v.5

- “We did not yield submission even for an hour”
- “that the truth of the gospel might continue with you”

ἐλευθερίαν liberty — every believer's from the moment of faith

Add one thing to the gospel and you have made it a false gospel. Separate what you should do from what you have to do: believe.

What the apostles did — and did not do

Galatians 2:6–10 · Outline II.C.3 — Reaction of the apostles

a · v.6	Added nothing to Paul's gospel — God shows personal favoritism to no man	**πρόσωπον λαμβάνει** “receives the face” — judges by status
b · v.7	Saw his gospel was the same as Peter's — to Gentile and Jew alike	**πεπίστευμαι** Perf. Pass. — entrusted, and still so
c · v.8	Recognized the same power at work in Peter and in Paul	God gives the increase (1 Cor 3:6)
d · v.9	James, Peter and John gave the right hand of fellowship	**κοινωνίας** full partnership, one gospel
e · v.10	Asked only that they remember the poor — what Paul came to do	**πτωχῶν** a fruit of grace, not an addition

Discuss and apply

Galatians 1:18 – 2:10 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. Paul went to Jerusalem “by revelation” and discussed his gospel almost as an aside. What does that order of events protect?

2. What two-fold purpose did the false brothers have in 2:4, and how does καταδουλόω (“to enslave”) describe the stakes?

Apply

Not Yielding, Not Even for an Hour
Practice stating the gospel this week in one sentence, with nothing added to “believe.”

Bring the Relief, Discuss the Gospel Along the Way
Meet one practical need for someone in your church family this week, without waiting for a “spiritual” reason.

In one line: Jerusalem added nothing to Paul's gospel. There is one gospel — and the ground is level at the cross.